



# Tongues in Acts and Corinthians

## UNDERSTANDING TWO DIFFERENT CONTEXTS

Scripture presents tongues in different ministry settings and for different purposes. In Acts, tongues function primarily as a public sign connected to the Gospel's expansion. In 1 Corinthians, Paul addresses the orderly use of tongues within the gathered church, emphasizing interpretation and edification.



### TONGUES IN ACTS 2

#### PUBLIC SIGN AT PENTECOST

- ✓ **Known Human Languages** – The hearers identified the apostles speaking in the languages of their own regions. (Acts 2:5–11)
- ✓ **Immediate Understanding** – No interpretation was needed; the message was heard and understood by the crowd.
- ✓ **Public Proclamation** – A sign to authenticate the gospel to Israel and the nations.
- ✓ **Sign Connected to Pentecost** – This outpouring fulfilled Joel's prophecy and accompanied the inauguration of the church age. (Acts 2:16–21)
- ✓ **Multinational Audience** – Devout Jews from every nation were present in Jerusalem.
- ✓ **Result** – The message was heard, understood, and many were added to the church.



#### Acts 2:5–11

They heard them speaking in their own languages the mighty works of God.



### TONGUES IN 1 CORINTHIANS

#### EDIFICATION IN THE CHURCH

- ✓ **Interpretation Required** – Unlike Acts 2, Paul requires that tongues be interpreted in order to edify the church. (1 Cor. 14:13, 27–28)
- ✓ **Congregational Context** – The focus is on orderly worship, intelligibility, and building up the body.
- ✓ **Different Purpose** – In the gathered church, tongues are for edification; prophecy builds up and encourages believers. (1 Cor. 14:3–5)
- ✓ **Regulated Use** – Paul gives instructions for orderly use in corporate worship: by two or three, one at a time, with an interpreter. (1 Cor. 14:26–28)



#### 1 Corinthians 14:5, 13, 27–28

I would that ye all spake with tongues... Let all things be done for edification.



### KEY VERSES

#### Acts 2:4–11

They were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak in other tongues as the Spirit gave them utterance.

#### Acts 10:44–46

The Holy Spirit fell on the Gentiles as they heard Peter speaking.

#### 1 Corinthians 14:5

I would that ye all spake with tongues, but rather that ye prophesied.

#### 1 Corinthians 14:27–28

If any man speak in an unknown tongue, let it be by two, or at the most by three, and that by course; and let one interpret. But if there be no interpreter, let him keep silence in the church; and let him speak to himself, and to God.



### KEY TRUTHS

- Scripture teaches the reality of tongues in both settings.
- Acts 2 highlights a public sign to authenticate the gospel.
- 1 Corinthians 14 addresses order, interpretation, and edification in the church.
- Different contexts, different emphases—both are true to Scripture.



### RELATED RESOURCES



#### Articles

See related RC1 articles online.



#### Visual Theology

Explore the diagram on gifts of the Spirit.



#### Workbook

Complete the RC1 study guide.



#### Glossary

See: Tongues, Gifts of the Spirit, Edification, Interpretation.

### SIDE-BY-SIDE COMPARISON

| FEATURE                                                                                                           | ACTS 2                                        | 1 CORINTHIANS 14                           |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
|  <b>Audience</b>               | Multinational crowd in Jerusalem              | Local church in Corinth                    |
|  <b>Languages</b>              | Known human languages                         | Not identified; interpretation needed      |
|  <b>Interpretation Needed?</b> | Understood by hearers in their own languages  | Yes, for edification of believers          |
|  <b>Purpose</b>                | Public sign to authenticate the gospel        | Edification and order in corporate worship |
|  <b>Setting</b>                | Pentecost (inauguration of the church age)    | Church assembly (ongoing instruction)      |
|  <b>Result</b>                 | Message understood; many believed (Acts 2:41) | Edification of the church (1 Cor. 14:26)   |



### THE BOTTOM LINE

Tongues appear in Scripture in different contexts and for different purposes. In Acts, they authenticate the gospel to unbelievers. In 1 Corinthians, Paul regulates their use so the church may be edified. Interpretation is not denied—it is essential.



### TEACHER NOTE

Help learners see how context shapes the meaning and function of spiritual gifts. Encourage humility, love, and order as we study and practice these truths together.